



PLAN IN PLACE ED officials take former Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren in judicial custody on February 1 in Ranchi; inset, JMM's new leader of the legislative party Champai Soren

SOMNATH SEN

JHARKHAND/ HEMANT SOREN

Arrested, But Not Cornered

By Amitabh Srivastava

The ED case of money-laundering against Soren pertains to an alleged land scam. Soren has been linked to the alleged proceeds of crime connected to the sale and purchase of army land in Ranchi, in which IAS officer Chhavi Ranjan, who was arrested in May 2023, is also an accused. In this case, the ED probe claimed to have uncovered the allegedly illegal sale and purchase of another eight-acre piece of land in Ranchi's Bargain area. Soren has denied all charges and clarified that the plot of land was "wrongfully alleged to be owned" by him. The land is not mentioned in the list of 27 immovable properties the CM has declared to the ED. Soren's arrest was made a day after the ED seized Rs 36 lakh in cash and a luxury SUV from his Delhi residence. Hours before his arrest, Soren lodged an FIR against senior ED officials under the SC/ST Act, alleging that the search at his Delhi home was conducted to "harass and malign him and his entire community". He also denied owning the car or any illegitimate cash.

Soren's arrest closed a year-long confrontation between the agency and the CM, who ignored seven summons in 2023 and one in 2024 before inviting the ED to his residence for questioning on January 20. The follow-up questioning on December 31 led to his arrest.

Last year, Soren had also approached the Supreme Court and the Jharkhand High Court, arguing that the ED action against him was a case of the Centre's misuse of agencies to destabilise "the democratically elected government". The courts refused to stay the summons.

Soren's arrest is unlikely to precipitate a political crisis in Jharkhand as the ruling alliance has a comfortable majority in the House. Immediately after Soren's resignation, a group of legislators visited Raj Bhavan, and newly anointed leader of the legislative party and the alliance Champai Soren, also the state transport minister, staked claim to form the new government with the support of 47 MLAs. On February 1, Champai again met the governor with several MLAs from the ruling alliance.

The Jharkhand assembly has a strength of 82. The JMM, Congress and RJD have 29, 17 and one MLA, respectively in alliance. In the Opposition, the BJP has 26 and the All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU) three. The CPI(M-L) and Nationalist Congress Party-Ajit Pawar (NCP-AP) have one MLA each besides two independents.

Soren's arrest just months before the Lok Sabha polls and his slogan—"*Na darenge na jhukenge*" (we'll neither be scared nor bow down)—is likely to keep the issue on the boil. The JMM believes it can rouse the tribal communities in the state. Jharkhand, a state with 28 per cent tribal population, has 28 of the 82 assembly seats and five of the 14 Lok Sabha constituencies reserved for scheduled tribes. Soren, from the Santhal tribal community, is trying to project his arrest as the Centre's "anti-tribal" stand.

The Jharkhand BJP, led by Babulal Marandi, another Santhal leader, has long accused Soren of corruption, but the BJP will now have to walk the extra mile to prevent a tribal backlash. The BJP did very well in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, winning 11 seats. But, the following December, it lost power to the JMM-Congress-RJD combine in the assembly polls. Also, the BJP could win only two of the 28 reserved ST seats—the JMM-Congress won 25 seats. The stakes are high for both camps, with Jharkhand voting twice this year. ■

RANCHI RUMBLE

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